

GOOD TO KNOW

Assisted conception

Some couples who want to have children don't find it easy to become pregnant. Becoming pregnant is known as conception, and not conceiving is known as "infertility." Infertility can have many causes, and many different treatments, too. Some females don't produce eggs regularly, but this can often be treated by stimulating the ovaries with drugs. In other cases, the fallopian tubes may be blocked, which stops the sperm and egg from coming together, but this can be treated with delicate surgery, as can other problems in the uterus. Some males don't produce many sperm, and there are a variety of ways to treat this.

In vitro fertilization (IVF) is a medical method often used to help couples who can't conceive naturally. This involves collecting eggs from the ovaries and mixing them with sperm "in vitro" (in glassware or a laboratory dish). If fertilization occurs, the embryo can then be placed into the uterus, leading to a pregnancy.

Gestation

From fertilization to birth, pregnancy lasts for an average of 40 weeks. This is known as the gestation period.

12 weeks

12 weeks after conception, the placenta, which provides the fetus with oxygen and nutrients, is fully formed.

**20 weeks**

The fetus measures about 10 in (25 cm). It can hear voices from the outside world, and its sense of motion is developing.

**26 weeks**

The lungs and brain are developing. The fetus has periods of being asleep and awake. It moves around a lot, and can respond to light, touch, and sound.

**32–42 weeks**

The baby usually turns to be head-down, ready for birth. During labor—the process of delivering a baby once it is fully developed—the muscles in the uterus and vagina contract to push the baby through to the outside world.

